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Estelle El-Hai

IF YOU'VE GOT IT, DON'T LOSE IT

Before you decide not to lose it, you need to know what it is. There was Clara Bow, the "It" girl. She was pretty, had charisma and charm. What about the Marlboro Man and the Old Spice Guy on TV commercials? People would agree that they have it.

The old song, "She Had to Go and Lose it at the Astor" might not have anything to do with it. On the other hand, it could. Just today, I noticed a flyer in the Fitness Center. The heading was, "Lose it at the Fitness Center". If Sun City Residents haven't lost it yet, they really have a problem.

There was an article in today's paper, in the Chicken Soup column, where this middle aged woman was called, "Baby" by a truckdriver who was passing by. It made her wonder and ponder for the rest of the day, if she still had it. Evidently, the truckdriver thought so, and it secretly gave her titilating pleasure. That night,when her husband greeted her with, "Hey baby", she embraced him with gratitude and appreciation.

Does everyone have some kind of It? I believe that most people have the capacity to demonstrate it, but not everyone finds it important or relevant enough. If being charismatic, magnetic, interesting and fun is a strain, you ain't got it! Maybe there's a "spark" gene that you inherit, or develop while you're growing up. Also, it takes one to know one because chemistry comes into play. Let's do a little supposing:

He: "Nice to meet you. What's your horoscope sign?"
Conclusion: Boooring. He doesn't have it.
She: "You're the one I've heard about. Why should I be glad to meet you?"
Conclusion: There's a good possibility that she has it. Either that, or she's very conceited.
He: "Hi, I've been watching you all night."
Conclusion: A strong maybe.
She: "Me too. What's your sign?"

Conclusion: She just blew it.

"It" should make you and the people around you happy and excited. Flashing a light of humor and curiosity, the mood is contagious and inspiring. The fortunate person who possesses this trait is intrigued with others and what makes them tick. The recipient is made to feel better about himself and suddenly feels more worthy and intelligent.

Analyzing my family history, I know without hesitation that my mother had it. She drew people to her like moths to a light. Mama Bella was open minded, clever, fun to be with, and thoroughly enjoyed people. Relatives came to her for advice and she made them own up to their actions. One of her faults was also a blessing…she embroidered the truth and made it even truthier. She could get into the mind of a child, and still trickier, into the motives of a teenager. Mama was very special.

The surprise factor was my father, Jack. In his generation, husbands worked from morning until night to support the family, and give them a few extras, like summers in the cooler Catskill Mountains. It was unheard of for men to talk to the kids about schoolwork or their ambitions. To help out with housework was unmentionable. His main way of disciplining us was to shpritz seltzer on us for not assisting our mother with the dishes. This was usually done while my sister and I were sprawled on the floor reading the Sunday comics, which were then called the "jokes".

Yet, in quiet moments, he would single me out and ask how I was doing in school and if I had any problems. There is an incident that I will never erase from my mind. It was in my twelfth year, when I was in the eighth grade. Elections for class officers were being planned and heretofore only boys were elected as presidents. That position was something I really coveted. I expressed my concerns to my father, who took my hand in his and looked me in the eyes with his ocean-blue ones.

"If it can be done, you can do it. Figure out a way to make your friends happy to help you." He had built a successful business from scratch during the depression and I never forgot his valuable advice.

I began collecting Sunday "jokes" from the neighbors, and cut out popular characters. Do you remember, L'il Abner, The Katzenjammer Kids, Flash Gorden, Dick Tracy, and The Dragon Lady? I glued these celebrities on cards, wrote "Vote for Estelle for Pres." with a straight pin on top. So many were glad to wear my campaign cards as it made them laugh and talk it up to others.

In my graduation class picture, I'm smack dab in the center as president of my class. My father was right, and his precious quote was repeated many times to my children. Hopefully, they'll remember that their grandfather had it.

Whatever your definition of this characteristic might be, if you think you've got it, don't lose it…choose it…use it!

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